Scientists discover 180,000 giant tortoises on one Seychelles island

Free-roaming Aldabra population far exceeds human population of Seychelles after decades-long recovery programme

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Giant tortoise population thriving as survey discovers 180,000 on one island. Photograph: Dennis Hansen/SWNS

A survey of the world’s largest free-roaming giant tortoise population has discovered that the once endangered species is thriving.

A population of Aldabra giant tortoises lives on an island in Seychelles called Aldabra Atoll.

The most recent survey, led by Seychelles Islands Foundation (SIF) and the University of Exeter, revealed there were approximately 180,000 tortoises living on the island. This is the highest figure ever recorded for the species and far exceeds the human population of Seychelles.

The new figure was obtained by a team who analysed five years of tortoise counts between 2018 and 2022. It is the first update since a widely cited figure of 100,000 tortoises from the late 1990s.

Aldabra Atoll is one of only two places in the world where giant tortoises are found in the wild, with a much smaller population living in the Galápagos.

Dr Frauke Fleischer-Dogley, the CEO of SIF, said: “More than 180,000 giant tortoises roaming freely on our atoll is proof of what long-term commitment to conservation can achieve. This is wonderful news for Seychelles, for the world, and for everyone who has worked to protect Aldabra.”



There are more giant tortoises on Aldabra Atoll than humans. Photograph: Avalon.red/Alamy

The study, published in the scientific journal Ecology and Evolution, found that the population was relatively stable for this period, with a best estimate of almost 183,000 adult and sub-adult tortoises.

In the 19th century, exploitation of the animals meant there were fewer than 1,000 Aldabra tortoises left on the island, but a recovery programme led to it becoming a strict nature reserve in 1981 and a Unesco site in 1982.

Researchers are now saying it is one of the greatest conservation success stories of the Indian Ocean, with the new study confirming it. “Aldabra’s giant tortoise monitoring programme is one of the longest running in the region, but the atoll’s dense vegetation makes counting tortoises genuinely difficult in places,” said Dr Nancy Bunbury, one of the study’s co-authors.

“By modelling what we didn’t see, as well as what we did, we’ve produced the most reliable baseline yet for this iconic Seychelles species, establishing a benchmark we can use to track the population for decades to come.”

Despite the good news, the study’s authors say that vigilance is essential. Aldabra’s climate is changing, with longer and more frequent droughts predicted to reduce the shade and food available to tortoises, while rising sea levels threaten low-lying parts of the atoll.

The study authors say invasive mammals remain a threat including feral cats and black rats that prey on tortoise eggs and hatchlings. The planned eradication of these remaining invasive mammals, the authors say, could lift the last barriers to further growth of the population and help it withstand future climate pressures.

“These results are great news for the tortoises and testament to the fantastic work done in the field,” said Dr Dave Hudson, a postdoctoral research associate at the University of Exeter’s Cornwall campus.

“But it’s important to remember that the numbers provide a baseline – not an endpoint.

“Hopefully we have provided the conservation managers the evidence they need to track future change and act early as the tortoises face increasing pressures from climate change, drought and invasive species.”

生词标注（新闻高频 + 词汇第二义项）

词	词性	中文	备注
figure	n.	数字、数据；（书中的）图表；人物	“the highest figure ever recorded for the species” 该物种有记录以来的最高数字；本义“人物、身影”，新闻中 figures 常指统计

词	词性	中文	备注
			数据，如 official figures 官方数据
thriving	v.	兴旺、茁壮成长（thrive 的现在分词）	“the once endangered species is thriving” 这个一度濒危的物种如今生机勃勃；thrive on sth 表“靠……兴旺”
survey	n. / v.	调查、普查；（实地）勘测	“A survey of the world’s largest free-roaming giant tortoise population” 对全球最大野生巨龟种群的调查；动词另有“总体审视”义
estimate	n. / v.	估计、估算值	“with a best estimate of almost 183,000 adult and sub-adult tortoises” 最优估计为近 18.3 万只成体与亚成体（sub-adult 亚成体）；科研报道常用 best/rough estimate
counts	n.	计数、清点数字（count 的复数）	“five years of tortoise counts between 2018 and 2022” 2018 至 2022 年五年的象龟计数；另义“罪名、事项”，如 on all counts 在所有方面
exploitation	n.	（对野生动物的）捕猎利用、开发；剥削	“exploitation of the animals meant there were fewer than 1,000 Aldabra tortoises left” 对它们的捕猎利用使岛上仅存不到 1000 只；动词 exploit
reserve	n. / v.	（自然）保护区；储备；预订	“it becoming a strict nature reserve in 1981” 1981 年它成为严格的自然保护区；第二义项“储备、保留”常见于 in reserve

词	词性	中文	备注
vigilance	n.	警惕、警觉	“the study’s authors say that vigilance is essential” 研究作者表示警惕不可或缺；形容词 vigilant，反义 complacency（自满）
low-lying	adj.	低洼的、地势低的	“rising sea levels threaten low-lying parts of the atoll” 海平面上升威胁环礁的低洼地带；气候报道高频
invasive	adj.	入侵性的、外来的（物种等）	“invasive mammals remain a threat” 外来入侵哺乳动物仍是威胁；生态学核心词，常搭 invasive species 入侵物种
feral	adj.	野化的、回归野性的	“including feral cats and black rats” 包括野化猫与黑鼠；指家养动物逃逸后野化，区别于原生野生 wild
prey on	phr.	捕食、猎食	“black rats that prey on tortoise eggs and hatchlings” 捕食龟卵与幼龟的黑鼠；第二义项“使……受害、折磨”，如 prey on sb’s fears
hatchlings	n.	刚孵化的幼崽、幼龟	“tortoise eggs and hatchlings” 龟卵与幼龟；hatch（孵化）+ -ling（幼小后缀）
eradication	n.	根除、剿灭	“The planned eradication of these remaining invasive mammals” 计划根除这些残留的入侵哺乳动物；动词 eradicate，如 eradication of poverty 消除贫困

词	词性	中文	备注
withstand	v.	经受住、承受	“help it withstand future climate pressures” 帮助它承受未来的气候压力；常搭 withstand pressure / shocks
testament	n.	明证、证明（a testament to sth）	“testament to the fantastic work done in the field” 是实地工作出色的明证；语气比 proof 更强调“见证、见证物”
baseline	n.	基线、基准数据	“the most reliable baseline yet for this iconic Seychelles species” 该标志性物种迄今最可靠的基线数据；科研与统计高频
benchmark	n. / v.	基准、标杆；以……为基准衡量	“establishing a benchmark we can use to track the population” 建立一个可用于长期跟踪种群的基准；比 baseline 更强调“比较用的标杆”
endpoint	n.	终点；（研究的）终点指标	“the numbers provide a baseline – not an endpoint” 这些数字是基线，而非终点；医学试验中常见 primary endpoint 主要终点
exceed	v.	超过、超出	“far exceeds the human population of Seychelles” 远超塞舌尔本国人口；报道数据对比高频，常搭 far / vastly exceed